the whole 10-over deal. Yes, I was known – and still am – for my breakthrough spells. I remember getting Sachin out a few times. I also fondly recall dismissing Ricky Ponting quite a few times. There was a seven-wicket haul I got against the Windies. I was the highest wicket-taker in the 2011 World Cup. By the late 2000s, I eventually transitioned to being a better bowler than a batsman. But bowling is all about rhythm. And in the early years, neither my coaches nor my skippers trusted me to bloom into a full-time bowler. That's a pity because I was called into the Pakistan team as a bowler who could bat too – not the other way around.

Have you heard about the all-rounder's conundrum? No? Try it on for size: what feels better – hitting the world's most dangerous bowler for a six or dislocating the middle stump of the planet's finest batsman? Tough question, eh? That's what you call the all-rounder's conundrum.

In my case, what's my bigger fantasy? Hitting McGrath for a six or getting Ponting out? Well, neither really, because I did both and did them enough. But the answer, frankly, is that both made me happy as hell – a different kind of happy. I've always wondered whether I'm happier smacking the ball out of the park or dismissing big batsmen home to their wives. Honestly, I think it depends on the moment.

You have to see the moment coming, though. At least, you should try to. Forget the fleeting moment of the crucial dismissal, or the match-winning six. Let's talk about the big one. Let's talk about marriage.

I had an arranged marriage. I lived my bachelor years to the fullest. I made a lot of friends, enjoyed a very active social life and partied hard. But when it came to marriage, I trusted my parents with making the right choice. It's the way things are with our family.

It started with my dad. One evening, he summoned me to the terrace to speak to me in private. When I went to him, he announced very nonchalantly that I had been engaged to be married. I didn't think twice, nor did I ask any questions. I just said, 'That's great news, Baba!' My father was actually surprised. He was expecting me to question him and the decision he'd made for me. Maybe because I was *that* son, the one who was the outlier to the family's narrative about jobs and stability. But I did not. And he loved me for it. I remember his eyes teared up that moment as he hugged me.

I loved my parents equally and it was tough losing them both. They departed at different times. My father struggled for years – seven to be precise – with cancer. I was more prepared for his passing away. I was older too. But the way I lost my mother hurt more. She had just said her afternoon prayer and was settling down to take a nap with her prayer beads. She lay down, and never woke up. Her prayer beads were still in her hands. She was 52 years old. At the time, I was maybe 20 or 21 years old. I remember, she would pray that she never become a burden on any of us during old age. Maybe, her prayers were heard and she left us too soon. That afternoon, when she passed away, my life paused and things came to a standstill for quite a while. It was a difficult time.

But with loss, God also teaches you patience. After my mother's death, I started touring more. I found form. I recovered. But I never moved on. I don't think I'm over her loss, even now. I was more prepared when Baba left us. Not when she did.

Our *qismet* is in our hands. There is even a *hadith* about how we can change our fate. We can change it all if we want. But in my culture, they say that women bring their own luck to the family. Things changed for the better when I got married. Over the years, I became father to four